



Triumphant quartet: The Indian men's 4x100m relay team — comprising (above, L-R) Borgohain, Gurindervir, Kujur and Hoblidhar — broke the national record while representing Reliance at the National Relay Carnival in Chandigarh in April.

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But to progress further, Hillier and his athletes have little in terms of immediate gains — except how they exploit the baton exchange zone.

"The most critical part of the relay is the speed at which the baton moves through the box. If someone isn't brave coming into the box, the

outgoing runner can't push out hard enough. All our changeovers in Chandigarh were very safe — we played it safe because I wanted them to get the record, to make a statement," said Hillier, Athletics Director at Reliance Foundation, in a conversation with *Sportstar*.

"What you want is to exchange the baton towards the end of the box. That's the fastest method, because the outgoing runner has been accelerating longer and is moving faster."

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Pushing the limits of the exchange zone increases the risk of disqualification, but it's a trade-off James Hillier and his team are willing to make.